

PERSONAL READING SERIES

TIBETAN VAJRAYANA

BUDDHISM AND BON

*The Diamond Vehicle, the Ancient Shamanic Root,
the Bardo, Dzogchen, and the Living Tradition
of Tibet's Sacred World*

*On the roof of the world, two traditions met.
Bon — the ancient shamanic religion of Tibet —
and Vajrayana Buddhism arriving from India.*

*What they produced together is the most complete
map of consciousness, death, and liberation
ever assembled by a human civilization.*

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INTRODUCTION

The Roof of the World and Its Sacred Inheritance

Tibet sits on the highest plateau on earth — an average elevation of over 4,500 meters, surrounded by the Himalayas to the south and the Kunlun mountains to the north, isolated by geography from the rest of the world in a way that allowed its sacred tradition to develop with unusual depth and continuity. The combination of extreme altitude, dramatic landscape, brutal winters, and the specific quality of light at that elevation produced a culture whose relationship to the sacred is among the most complete and most thoroughly documented in human history.

Tibet's sacred inheritance comes from two distinct sources that met, contested, and eventually synthesized over approximately a thousand years. Bon — the ancient indigenous shamanic and animist tradition of the Tibetan plateau, with roots in the Zhang Zhung civilization that preceded the Tibetan Empire — was the original sacred world of Tibet. Vajrayana Buddhism arrived from India beginning in the 7th century CE, was temporarily suppressed, returned more powerfully in the 11th century, and over subsequent centuries interpenetrated with Bon so thoroughly that contemporary Tibetan Buddhism carries Bon elements that are inseparable from the Buddhist transmission.

What Tibet produced from this synthesis is the most complete and most explicitly documented sacred tradition in the world — a tradition that mapped consciousness, the dying process, the after-death experience, the nature of mind, the structure of reality, and the path to liberation with a precision and depth that remains unmatched in the global sacred literature. The Tibetan Book of the Dead alone is without parallel in any tradition for its specificity about what happens to consciousness after the body dies.

BON — THE ANCIENT SHAMANIC RELIGION OF TIBET

Bon (pronounced 'pern' in classical Tibetan, from the verb 'to chant' or 'to recite') is the indigenous religious tradition of the Tibetan plateau — predating the arrival of Buddhism by an unknown but significant period. Bon is not a primitive animism that Buddhism superseded. It is a sophisticated religious system with its own cosmology, its own priesthood (the Bonpo), its own sacred texts, its own meditation practices, and its own path to liberation — which it calls Dzogchen, using the same term that the Nyingma school of Tibetan Buddhism uses for its highest teaching.

The relationship between Bon and Tibetan Buddhism is one of the most complex and most contested questions in Tibetan religious studies. The traditional Buddhist account presents Bon as a degenerated tradition that incorporated Buddhist elements after Buddhism's arrival. The Bon tradition's own account presents it as the original teaching of Tonpa Shenrab Miwoche — a pre-Buddhist teacher of enlightenment who predates Siddhartha Gautama by thousands of years. Contemporary scholarship suggests that Bon and Buddhism developed in parallel, each influencing the other deeply, producing the specific synthesis that characterizes the Tibetan sacred world.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: Bon is to Tibetan Buddhism what the Taoist and Confucian traditions are to Chinese Buddhism — the indigenous sacred soil into which the foreign transmission planted itself and from which it drew nourishment that transformed both. You cannot fully understand Tibetan Buddhism without understanding Bon. And Haligrity recognizes Bon as one of the oldest living shamanic traditions on earth — a tradition that has been practicing what the Haligrity framework calls direct energetic relationship with the living world for millennia.**

The Three-World Cosmology

Bon cosmology divides reality into three realms: the upper realm (Yeru) of sky and divine beings, the middle realm (Bardu) of the human world and its spirits, and the lower realm (Yodu) of underground waters and earth spirits. This three-world structure is the universal shamanic cosmological map — identical in its basic architecture to the Siberian shamanic tradition, the Norse world tree (Yggdrasil's three roots), the Slavic tradition's three realms, and the indigenous American traditions that recognize upper, middle, and lower worlds.

The Bon universe is populated by a vast array of spirit beings: the lha (divine beings of the upper realm, associated with sky, mountains, and positive forces), the tsen (warrior spirits of the middle realm, associated with rocks and passes), the lu (serpentine beings of the lower realm, associated with water and earth — closely related to the Indian naga). These spirit beings are not distant cosmic forces but immediate neighbors whose territories overlap with human territory, whose moods and states directly affect human wellbeing, and whose ongoing relationship with human communities requires constant careful maintenance.

The Soul in Bon Tradition

Bon recognizes multiple soul components in the human being — a complex soul anatomy that parallels the Egyptian Ka/Ba/Akh system, the Yoruba concept of Ori and multiple soul parts, and the Chinese understanding of po and hun souls. The la is the life soul — the vital force that animates the body and that can be captured, frightened away, or lost during illness or trauma. The Bon shaman's primary healing function is the retrieval of the la — journeying to wherever it has been taken or fled and returning it to the patient.

The Bon Shaman — The Bonpo

The Bonpo (Bon priest/shaman) serves multiple functions in traditional Tibetan communities: healer (through soul retrieval and spirit negotiation), diviner (reading the state of the spirit world and its implications for human affairs), funeral specialist (guiding the soul of the deceased through the transition — a function that pre-dates and parallels the Bardo Thodol's later role), and ritual specialist maintaining right relationship between the human community and the spirit beings of all three worlds. The Bonpo's primary tools are the drum (for journeying between worlds), specific chants and ritual formulas, and sacred substances used in offerings to the various spirit beings.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Bon soul retrieval tradition is the most direct precedent for the Living Altar concept developed in Haligricity — the understanding that soul fragments lost during trauma can be retrieved and returned through intentional sacred practice. The Bonpo who journeys to find the la of a traumatized patient and the Haligric practitioner who sends love through the overlapping realities to the child-self who needed it are working with the same understanding: that time is non-linear, that soul fragments are retrievable, and that intentional sacred attention can reach what ordinary time says is unreachable.

The Zhang Zhung civilization — centered in western Tibet around Mount Kailash (the most sacred mountain in the Bon, Hindu, Jain, and Buddhist traditions simultaneously) — is the source of the most ancient layer of the Bon tradition. Zhang Zhung was a sophisticated civilization with its own language (Zhang Zhung language, now extinct), its own sacred texts, and its own high culture. It was conquered by the Tibetan Empire in approximately the 7th century CE.

Mount Kailash (Tise in Zhang Zhung, Gang Rinpoche in Tibetan — Precious Snow Mountain) is the axis mundi of the Bon tradition — the world pillar around which the cosmos revolves, the home of the sky god Sipaimen, and the sacred center from which the four great rivers of Asia (the Indus, the Brahmaputra, the Karnali/Ganges tributary, and the Sutlej) flow outward in the four directions. The Bon tradition's circumambulation of Mount Kailash goes counter-clockwise (the reverse of the Buddhist circumambulation direction) — and both traditions have been circling the mountain simultaneously for over a thousand years.

The Bon tradition's highest teaching — called Dzogchen (Great Perfection) — claims to have originated in Zhang Zhung and to predate the Buddhist Dzogchen transmission. Whether Bon Dzogchen and Buddhist Dzogchen have independent origins or share a common source remains debated, but the two traditions' Dzogchen teachings are so similar that masters of both have been known to receive teachings from teachers of the other — one of the most remarkable examples of cross-traditional recognition in the history of Asian religion.

HOW BUDDHISM CAME TO TIBET — THE THREE TRANSMISSIONS

The First Transmission — King Songtsen Gampo (7th century)

Buddhism first arrived in Tibet during the reign of King Songtsen Gampo (approximately 617-649 CE) — the first great Tibetan emperor, who unified the Tibetan plateau and married two Buddhist princesses: Bhrikuti from Nepal and Wencheng from Tang dynasty China. Both wives brought Buddhist statues and texts to Lhasa, and Songtsen Gampo supported the development of the Tibetan script (by the minister Thonmi Sambhota) to enable the translation of Buddhist texts into Tibetan. The Jokhang Temple in Lhasa — the holiest site in Tibetan Buddhism — was built to house the statue brought by Princess Wencheng.

The First Diffusion — King Trisong Detsen (8th century)

The decisive moment in the Buddhification of Tibet came under King Trisong Detsen (742-797 CE), who invited two of the most important figures in Tibetan Buddhist history to Tibet: the Indian Buddhist scholar Santaraksita and the Tantric master Padmasambhava (known in Tibet as Guru Rinpoche — Precious Teacher). Santaraksita established the philosophical and monastic foundation; Padmasambhava subdued the local spirits and demons who were obstructing Buddhism's establishment — the most significant act of Bon-Buddhist synthesis in Tibetan history, as many of these spirits were incorporated into the Buddhist pantheon as protectors rather than destroyed.

The first Tibetan monastery — Samye — was built under Trisong Detsen's patronage in approximately 779 CE. The Great Debate at Samye (approximately 792-794 CE) — between the Indian gradualist Buddhist position (championed by Kamalashila, Santaraksita's student) and the Chinese sudden awakening position (championed by the Chan master Moheyan) — was a defining moment in Tibetan religious history. The Indian gradualist position won, setting the direction for Tibetan Buddhism's emphasis on the complete systematic path rather than sudden enlightenment.

The Persecution and Second Diffusion (9th-11th century)

King Langdarma (reigned 838-842 CE) reversed the Buddhist gains of his predecessors — suppressing monasteries, forcing monks to laicize, and destroying texts in a persecution that nearly extinguished Tibetan Buddhism. After Langdarma's assassination by the Buddhist monk Palgyi Dorje (who hid his bow under his black cloak, producing the tradition of the Cham mask dance), Buddhism gradually recovered over the following two centuries. The Second Diffusion — the reinvigoration of Tibetan Buddhism through new translations and new transmissions from India — was centered on the Indian master Atisha's arrival in Tibet in 1042 CE and produced the systematic structure of Tibetan Buddhism that persists today.

Padmasambhava (Sanskrit: Lotus-Born; Tibetan: Pema Jungne) is the single most important figure in Tibetan Buddhism — venerated as the Second Buddha by the Nyingma school and as the master who brought Vajrayana Buddhism to Tibet in its complete form. His biography is a mixture of history and sacred legend that the Nyingma tradition holds as simultaneously true at both levels.

The traditional biography describes Padmasambhava as having been born from a lotus flower on a lake in the land of Oddiyana (possibly in present-day Pakistan/Afghanistan) without human parents — already an enlightened being who chose to appear in the world for the benefit of beings. He received all tantric transmissions from the greatest masters of India and the dakinis (female enlightened beings) of the pure lands, and came to Tibet at King Trisong Detsen's invitation.

His most significant act in Tibet was the subjugation of the local spirits who were obstructing the construction of Samye monastery. Rather than destroying these beings, Padmasambhava bound them by oath to become protectors of the Dharma — transforming the spirit world of Bon into the dharmapalas (protectors) of Vajrayana Buddhism. This act is the theological explanation for why Tibetan Buddhism contains so many ferocious protective deities: they are the indigenous spirits of Tibet, transformed from obstacles into guardians.

Padmasambhava is also credited with hiding thousands of terma (treasure texts) throughout Tibet — sacred teachings concealed in rocks, earth, water, and the minds of specific disciples, to be revealed by designated treasure-finders (terton) in future centuries when humanity would be ready to receive them. The terma tradition has produced an extraordinary body of sacred literature across the centuries — including the Bardo Thodol, which was hidden by Padmasambhava and discovered by Karma Lingpa in the 14th century.

"In the sky of the mind, clouds of thought arise and dissolve.

The sky itself is never stained.

Rest in the sky. You are the sky."

— Padmasambhava, from the terma teachings

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: Padmasambhava's transformation of Tibet's indigenous spirits from obstacles into protectors is the most complete example of sacred synthesis in Tibetan history — and a model for the Haligric approach to every tradition. Nothing is destroyed. Everything is transformed. The energy that previously blocked the sacred work becomes, when correctly recognized and rightly related to, the guardian of it.**

Tibetan Buddhism crystallized into four major schools over the 11th-15th centuries — each with its own emphasis, its own transmission lineage, its own sacred texts, and its own distinctive practices, while sharing the common foundation of Vajrayana Buddhism and the Bodhisattva ideal.

SCHOOL	TIBETAN NAME	FOUNDED	KEY TEACHING	CURRENT HEAD
Nyingma	Ancient Ones	8th century CE	Dzogchen, Terma	No single head — collective
Kagyu	Oral Transmission	11th century CE	Mahamudra, Six Yogas	Karmapa (Gyalwang)
Sakya	Grey Earth	1073 CE	Lamdre (Path-Result)	Sakya Trizin
Gelug	Virtuous Way	14th century CE	Lam Rim (Stages of Path)	Dalai Lama / Ganden Tripa

Nyingma (Ancient Ones) is the oldest school of Tibetan Buddhism — tracing its origin directly to Padmasambhava's 8th-century transmission. The Nyingma school is distinguished by its nine-vehicle (theg pa rim pa dgu) structure of the Buddhist path — organizing all Buddhist teachings from the most basic to the most advanced into a comprehensive graduated system with Dzogchen at the apex.

The Nyingma school has no single institutional head — it is organized around a network of great masters and their lineages rather than a centralized authority. This decentralized structure made Nyingma more resilient to persecution but also more variable in institutional quality. Its great masters — Longchenpa (1308-1364), Jigme Lingpa (1730-1798), Dudjom Rinpoche (1904-1987) — are among the most celebrated teachers in all of Tibetan Buddhism.

The Nyingma school's primary practice transmission is the Longchen Nyingthig (Heart Essence of the Vast Expanse) — a terma cycle discovered by Jigme Lingpa that contains the most complete and most widely practiced Dzogchen teaching lineage in the contemporary world. Teachers like Dilgo Khyentse Rinpoche and Sogyal Rinpoche brought this lineage to Western students, making the Nyingma tradition one of the most accessible Tibetan Buddhist schools outside Tibet.

Terma (gter ma — treasure) are sacred teachings hidden by Padmasambhava and his consort Yeshe Tsogyal throughout Tibet for discovery by specific students in future centuries. The terma tradition is one of the most extraordinary concepts in any religious system — the idea that an enlightened master could plant teachings in the physical landscape and in the mental continuums of specific students across time, to be revealed when humanity would be ready to receive them.

Terma come in several forms. Sa-ter (earth treasures) are physical objects — texts, ritual objects, sacred substances — hidden in rocks, earth, trees, and water, to be discovered by tertön (treasure discoverers) in specific future lifetimes. Gong-ter (mind treasures) arise directly from the mindstream of the tertön — teachings that Padmasambhava planted in the tertön's previous-life consciousness and that arise spontaneously in meditation, often fully formed. Bar-do ter (bardo treasures) are revealed in the transitional state between death and rebirth.

The greatest terma discoveries include the Bardo Thodol (Karma Lingpa, 14th century), the Longchen Nyingthig (Jigme Lingpa, 18th century), and the Rinchen Terdzo — the great treasury of precious termas compiled by Jamgon Kongtrul in the 19th century. The tertön Dudjom Lingpa (1835-1904) discovered some of the most significant Dzogchen termas of the modern era, and his son Dudjom Rinpoche brought them to the West in the 20th century.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The terma tradition is the most literal expression in any tradition of the understanding that sacred knowledge can be transmitted across time — that a teaching planted in the consciousness of a student by an enlightened master can flower centuries later when the conditions are right. The Haligric Living Altar concept — sending love to past selves and past versions of one's children through the non-linear nature of time — operates on the same understanding: that intentional sacred energy transcends linear time and reaches its destination when the recipient is ready.

Kagyu (Oral Transmission) traces its lineage through the Indian mahasiddha Tilopa (928-1009 CE) to Naropa (1016-1100 CE) to the Tibetan translator Marpa (1012-1097 CE) to Milarepa (1040-1123 CE) — one of the most beloved and most human figures in all of Tibetan sacred history — to Gampopa (1079-1153 CE), who established the Kagyu as a distinct school with its own monastic and teaching institutions.

The Kagyu school's primary transmission is Mahamudra (Great Seal) — the direct recognition of the nature of mind as it is, without elaboration or modification. Mahamudra practice involves specific pointing-out instructions from a qualified teacher who directly introduces the student to the nature of their own mind — followed by the student's sustained practice of resting in that recognition. The Kagyu also preserves the Six Yogas of Naropa — advanced tantric practices including tummo (inner heat), the illusory body, dream yoga, luminosity yoga, bardo yoga, and consciousness transference (phowa).

The Karmapa — the head of the Karma Kagyu sub-school — was the first major Tibetan Buddhist figure to establish the institution of recognized reincarnation (tulku), predating the Dalai Lama institution by approximately two centuries. The current Karmapa lineage is contested between two claimants recognized by different factions — a dispute that reflects the broader political dimensions of Tibetan Buddhism's relationship with Chinese occupation.

Milarepa (Mila Repa — Cotton-Clad Mila) is the most beloved figure in all of Tibetan sacred tradition — a man who began his spiritual life as a sorcerer who killed thirty-five of his relatives through black magic and ended it as one of the most fully realized masters in Tibetan Buddhist history. His story is the most dramatic account of transformation through genuine practice in the tradition.

After performing the acts of black magic that killed his relatives (at his mother's instigation, to avenge the mistreatment of their family), Milarepa was consumed by terror at the karma he had created and sought out the teacher Marpa to receive instruction in the Dharma. Marpa — knowing what was needed — put Milarepa through eleven years of the most grueling tests before giving him any teaching: building towers of stone and then tearing them down and rebuilding them, repeatedly and without explanation, until Milarepa's pride and karma were sufficiently purified.

After finally receiving the complete Mahamudra transmission from Marpa, Milarepa spent the rest of his life meditating in the high caves of the Himalayan mountains — wearing only a cotton robe in the freezing altitude through the cultivation of tummo (inner heat) — and singing spontaneous songs of realization (dohas) that have become the most beloved sacred poetry in Tibetan literature. He is said to have achieved full enlightenment in a single lifetime.

"My religion is to live — and die — without regret."

*"Do not brood over your past mistakes and failures
as this will only fill your mind with grief, regret and depression.
Do not repeat them in the future."*

— Milarepa

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Milarepa's transformation from black magician to enlightened master is the Tibetan tradition's most complete expression of the Vajrayana teaching that the poison is the medicine. The same energy that drove his acts of murderous sorcery was the energy that drove his relentless practice. Nothing was wasted. Nothing was lost. Everything was transformed. This is what Haligricity means when it says the Tetralty directed toward any object with full force produces results — the question is only what it is directed toward.

Sakya (Grey Earth — named for the grey earth of the site where the monastery was built) was founded in 1073 CE by Khon Konchok Gyalpo, establishing the tradition of the Khon family as the hereditary heads of the Sakya school — a dynastic religious authority unique in Tibetan Buddhism. The Sakya school's primary teaching is Lamdre (Path-Result) — a comprehensive practice system integrating sutra and tantra transmitted in the lineage of the Indian mahasiddha Virupa.

The Sakya school had its greatest political moment in the 13th century when the Mongol ruler Godan Khan invited the Sakya Pandita (1182-1251 CE) to his court and the relationship between the Sakya hierarchs and the Mongol rulers developed into the 'patron-priest' relationship that gave the Sakya school temporal authority over Tibet under Mongol patronage. This political moment established the model of theocratic governance that would eventually be institutionalized through the Dalai Lama system.

Gelug (Virtuous Way) is the newest and now largest school of Tibetan Buddhism — founded by Je Tsongkhapa Lobzang Drakpa (1357-1419 CE) as a reform movement emphasizing strict monastic discipline, rigorous philosophical study, and a systematic graduated approach to the spiritual path. The Dalai Lama is the most recognized figure of the Gelug school and the most famous Tibetan Buddhist in the world.

Tsongkhapa's primary contribution is the Lam Rim (Stages of the Path) literature — systematic guides to the complete Buddhist path from initial engagement to full enlightenment. His Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path (Lam Rim Chenmo) is the most comprehensive systematic presentation of the complete Mahayana-Vajrayana path in Tibetan Buddhist literature. The Gelug emphasis on the graduated path — in contrast to the more sudden-awakening approaches of Dzogchen and Mahamudra — placed rigorous systematic study and practice at the foundation.

Gelug monasteries — particularly the three great monasteries of Ganden, Sera, and Drepung near Lhasa — became the largest monastic universities in the world, training thousands of monks in the most sophisticated Buddhist philosophical curriculum ever developed. The Geshe degree — earned through approximately twenty years of intensive study and debate — remains the highest academic degree in Tibetan Buddhism.

THE TULKU SYSTEM — RECOGNIZED REINCARNATIONS

The tulku (sprul sku — emanation body) system is one of the most distinctive institutions in Tibetan Buddhism — the recognition of specific individuals as reincarnations of previous masters, with all the authority and teachings of the previous life understood to be accessible through the new incarnation. The system was first established by the Kagyu school with the recognition of the second Karmapa in the 13th century.

The recognition process involves multiple elements: oracular consultation, dream and vision signs given to senior lamas, the child's own recognition of objects from the previous life, physical marks, and astrological confirmation. Once recognized, the tulku is typically brought to a monastery for training from a young age — entering a process of education that is understood as the recovery of the previous life's understanding rather than the acquisition of new knowledge.

The tulku system currently recognizes several thousand living tulkus worldwide — ranging from figures of enormous authority like the Dalai Lama and the Karmapa to local monastery heads whose recognition affects a small regional community. The system has come under strain in the contemporary period through the Chinese government's insistence on the right to approve tulku recognitions within China — a direct political intrusion into the most sacred institutional mechanism of Tibetan Buddhism.

◆ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The tulku system is the most institutionalized expression in any tradition of the understanding that consciousness continues across lifetimes and that specific threads of sacred transmission carry through from one body to the next. The Haligric understanding of the non-linear nature of time and the possibility of soul-level transmission across apparent temporal boundaries is what the tulku system institutionalizes. The institution may be imperfect. The recognition it is based on — that consciousness is not confined to a single body or a single lifetime — is one of the deepest recognitions in the tradition.

The Dalai Lama (Ocean Teacher — from the Mongolian 'Dalai' meaning ocean) institution began with the retroactive recognition of Gendun Drup (1391-1474 CE) as the First Dalai Lama. The institution became politically significant with the Fifth Dalai Lama (1617-1682 CE) — Ngawang Lobzang Gyatso, known as the Great Fifth — who with Mongol military support unified Tibet under Gelug leadership and built the Potala Palace in Lhasa.

The current and 14th Dalai Lama — Tenzin Gyatso, born 1935 — was recognized at age two, enthroned at age four, and assumed political leadership of Tibet at age fifteen in 1950 — the same year Chinese forces invaded Tibet. After the 1959 Tibetan uprising was suppressed, the Dalai Lama fled to Dharamsala in northern India, where the Tibetan Government in Exile has been based since. He received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1989 for his commitment to the non-violent resolution of the Tibetan question and his advocacy for universal human values.

The Dalai Lama has been the single most effective transmitter of Tibetan Buddhist teaching to the Western world — through his hundreds of books, his global teaching tours, and his decades of engagement with Western scientists, philosophers, and political leaders. His collaboration with neuroscientist Richard Davidson and the Mind and Life Institute has produced some of the most significant research on meditation and the neuroscience of contemplative practice.

Tibetan Vajrayana practice is organized around three objects of refuge called the Three Roots — the sources from which the practitioner draws the specific qualities needed for awakening. The Three Roots are the innermost expression of the Three Jewels (Buddha, Dharma, Sangha) specific to the Vajrayana path.

The Guru (Lama) — Root of Blessings

The Guru is the living teacher who transmits the Vajrayana path directly, heart to heart, from their own realization to the student's awakening potential. In Vajrayana understanding, the Guru is more important than the Buddha — because the historical Buddha is no longer accessible directly, while the living Guru is present. The teacher's realization acts like a tuning fork — the student's awareness resonates with the teacher's and gradually attains the same frequency. This is why the Guru Yoga (the meditation practice of merging one's mind with the Guru's mind) is considered the most important single practice in Vajrayana Buddhism.

The Yidam (Deity) — Root of Accomplishment

The Yidam is the meditational deity with whom the practitioner has a specific karmic connection — the specific face of the awakened mind that the practitioner's own nature most naturally expresses. Deity visualization practice (sadhana) involves dissolving the ordinary self-concept into emptiness and arising as the deity — not pretending to be the deity but recognizing that the deity's qualities (wisdom, compassion, power, purity) are already present in the practitioner's own nature and that the visualization is a technology for recognizing and stabilizing that recognition.

The Dakini — Root of Activity

The Dakini (Sky Dancer) is the feminine principle of awakened energy — the wild, unpredictable, wisdom-energized feminine that appears in Vajrayana as the consort of male deities, as independent enlightened female figures (Vajrayogini, Vajravahni, Tara), and as the principle of inspiration and transmission that moves through female teachers, through the practitioner's own intuitive wisdom, and through the energetic forces of the world. The Dakini tradition preserved and transmitted many of the most secret Vajrayana teachings.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Dakini is the Tibetan Buddhist expression of the divine feminine in its most wild, most energized, most non-institutionally-controlled form. Unlike the suppressed Heavenly Mother of LDS theology or the sidelined Sophia of Gnostic Christianity, the Dakini in Vajrayana is not a marginal figure but one of the three fundamental sources of the entire path. She dances in the sky. She cuts through delusion with her curved blade. She holds the skull cup of transformed consciousness. She is the energy of awakening that cannot be tamed, institutionalized, or silenced. The Haligric tradition honors her completely.

THE FIVE BUDDHA FAMILIES — COMPLETE REFERENCE

The Five Buddha Families (Panca Buddha Kula) are the Vajrayana system's most complete map of awakened mind — organizing the five basic qualities of enlightened awareness into five distinct expressions, each associated with a specific direction, color, element, wisdom, poison-transformed, and Buddha figure.

FAMILY	BUDDHA	DIRECTION	COLOR	WISDOM	TRANSFORMED POISON
Vajra	Akshobhya	East	Blue/White	Mirror-Like Wisdom	Anger / Hatred
Ratna	Ratnasambhava	South	Yellow/Gold	Equalizing Wisdom	Pride / Arrogance
Padma	Amitabha	West	Red	Discriminating Wisdom	Desire / Attachment
Karma	Amoghasiddhi	North	Green	All-Accomplishing Wisdom	Jealousy / Envy
Buddha	Vairochana	Center	White	Dharmadhatu Wisdom	Ignorance / Delusion

The Five Buddha Families are the Vajrayana map of what happens when the five poisons are recognized in their nature. Anger, directly seen, reveals the Mirror-Like Wisdom that perceives reality without distortion — like a mirror that reflects exactly what is there, adding nothing, distorting nothing. Pride, directly seen, reveals the Equalizing Wisdom that recognizes all beings as equally buddha in nature. Desire, directly seen, reveals the Discriminating Wisdom that perceives the unique particularity of every phenomenon with perfect clarity. Jealousy, directly seen, reveals the All-Accomplishing Wisdom that acts spontaneously and perfectly for the benefit of all. Ignorance, directly seen, reveals the Dharmadhatu Wisdom — the awareness of the nature of reality itself.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Five Buddha Families are the most complete expression in any tradition of the Haligric understanding that nothing in the human being's nature is an obstacle to be eliminated — everything is potential wisdom waiting to be recognized. The tradition does not ask you to stop feeling anger, desire, or jealousy. It asks you to look at what those energies actually are beneath the story that surrounds them. What you find is not a problem. It is a wisdom.

The Bardo Thodol (Liberation Through Hearing in the Bardo) — known in the West as the Tibetan Book of the Dead since W.Y. Evans-Wentz's 1927 translation — is the most complete and most specifically detailed account of the dying process, the after-death experience, and the process of rebirth in any sacred tradition on earth. It was hidden as a terma by Padmasambhava and discovered by the tertön Karma Lingpa in the 14th century.

The text is designed to be read aloud to a dying or recently deceased person by a lama or trained practitioner who knows the text intimately — guiding the consciousness of the dying person through the specific experiences of the three bardos with instructions for recognizing each stage and the specific actions to take at each moment. The title 'Liberation Through Hearing' refers to this function — the sound of the text entering the consciousness of even a practitioner who has not prepared well in life can trigger recognition that produces liberation.

The First Bardo — The Bardo of Dying

At the moment of death, the Bardo Thodol teaches that a luminous clear light — the ground luminosity or mother clear light — arises in the dying person's awareness. This is the fundamental nature of mind itself becoming directly visible as the ordinary consciousness dissolves. A practitioner who has prepared through Dzogchen or Mahamudra practice will recognize this clear light as the nature of their own mind and merge with it — achieving liberation at the moment of death. Those who do not recognize it continue into the second bardo.

The Second Bardo — The Bardo of Dharmata

In the second bardo, the consciousness encounters the peaceful and wrathful deities — a series of vivid appearances of the Five Buddha Families in their peaceful forms, followed by the same energies in their wrathful forms. Each appearance is accompanied by a brilliant colored light — the wisdom light of the specific Buddha family — alongside a softer, more seductive colored light representing the corresponding confused emotion's attractive pull. The instruction is always the same: recognize the brilliant wisdom light as your own nature and merge with it. Fear of the brilliance and attraction to the softer light leads to rebirth in the corresponding realm of samsara.

The Third Bardo — The Bardo of Becoming

The third bardo is the transitional state in which the consciousness moves toward rebirth — a hallucinatory experience of wind, darkness, and confusion in which the habitual tendencies of the previous life play out as vivid appearances. The text provides specific instructions for this stage: recognizing that all appearances are projections of one's own mind, choosing the best possible rebirth through specific visualizations and prayers,

and if nothing else succeeds, selecting a rebirth that will provide good conditions for continuing the spiritual path.

*"O nobly born, now the clear light of reality itself dawns upon you.
Recognize it. O nobly born, your present awareness, vacant, naked,
is itself the very reality, the All-Good.
Your own awareness, knowing, void, and naked,
is itself the very reality, the All-Good,
the unchanging light."*

— Bardo Thodol, instruction at the moment of death

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS:** The Bardo Thodol's instruction at the moment of death — recognize the clear light as your own nature — is the Vajrayana version of the same recognition that every mystical tradition points toward in life. Meister Eckhart's 'the eye through which I see God is the same eye through which God sees me.' The Vedantic 'Atman is Brahman.' The Sufi 'fana.' The Zen 'original face.' The Bardo Thodol presents the moment of death as the greatest opportunity for this recognition — when all the ordinary structures of consciousness dissolve and what was always there becomes unmistakably visible. The Haligric practitioner is, in every moment of genuine presence, practicing this recognition before the moment it will be required.

Dzogchen (rDzogs pa chen po — Great Perfection) is the highest teaching in both the Nyingma school of Tibetan Buddhism and the Bon tradition — the summit of the nine-vehicle system, the most direct and most complete path to the recognition of the nature of mind. It is considered a secret teaching transmitted only from teacher to student through direct pointing-out instruction (ngo sprod pa) — the teacher's direct introduction of the student to their own nature.

The central Dzogchen teaching is rigpa — the Tibetan word for the primordial awareness that is the nature of mind itself. Rigpa is not a state that is achieved through meditation. It is what is already the case — the unconditioned, self-luminous, spontaneously present awareness that underlies all experience and that is never absent even when not recognized. The difference between a Buddha and an ordinary person is not that the Buddha has more rigpa — it is that the Buddha recognizes rigpa and the ordinary person does not.

Dzogchen practice — called trekcho (cutting through) and togal (direct crossing) — involves resting in the recognition of rigpa without modification, elaboration, or correction, and then the further development of that recognition into the direct perception of the spontaneous display of rigpa as light. Advanced togal practitioners report specific visual phenomena — lights, spheres, chains of crystal spheres called thigle — that the tradition understands as the direct perception of consciousness's own natural energy.

The tradition of rainbow body (jalü) — in which highly realized Dzogchen practitioners at death leave no physical remains except hair and nails, their bodies dissolving into light — has been documented in hundreds of cases across Tibetan history and continues to be reported in contemporary times. The rainbow body phenomenon has attracted the attention of scientists including researchers connected to the Vatican's Pontifical Academy of Sciences, who began documenting cases in the early 2000s.

*"The nature of mind is like a mirror.
Thoughts and experiences are like reflections in it.
The mirror is never stained by the reflections.
The reflections do not change the mirror.
Rest as the mirror."*

— Nyingma Dzogchen teaching

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** Dzogchen is the Tibetan Buddhist tradition's most precise and most direct statement of the Haligric recognition: the divine does not live above the human being waiting to be earned or appeased. It IS the human being's own awareness — already present, already perfect, already complete. The only practice is recognition. The only obstacle is the habit of non-recognition. Everything the Haligric framework teaches about the divine living as the human being rather than above it is what Dzogchen calls rigpa. Different name. Exact same recognition.

Mahamudra (Great Seal) is the highest teaching of the Kagyu school and the parallel to Dzogchen in the Sarma (New Translation) schools. Like Dzogchen, Mahamudra points directly to the nature of mind — but through a slightly different approach that has been described as 'going with the grain' of experience rather than 'cutting through' it.

The Mahamudra pointing-out instruction typically involves three steps: the teacher demonstrates the nature of mind through a specific question or action that stops the ordinary conceptual process, the student has a direct glimpse of the nature of mind, and the teacher confirms the recognition. The subsequent practice of Mahamudra is the stabilization of that recognition — resting in the nature of mind while thoughts, emotions, and experiences arise and dissolve within it, like waves in an ocean that never leave the ocean.

The Mahamudra tradition includes specific instructions for working with thought in practice — neither suppressing thoughts nor following them, but recognizing the nature of the thought itself. When a thought arises and its nature is recognized as the display of rigpa, the thought self-liberates — it dissolves back into the ground of awareness without leaving a trace, just as a drawing on water disappears the moment it is made.

Thangka — Sacred Scroll Painting

Thangka (scroll painting) is the primary visual art form of Tibetan Buddhism — sacred images painted on cloth or applied in silk, depicting Buddhist deities, mandalas, lineage teachers, and cosmological scenes according to precise iconographic specifications. A thangka is not decorative art. It is a sacred object that has been blessed and consecrated — understood as the actual presence of the depicted being in visual form. The proportional systems, color codes, and symbolic elements of thangka painting are transmitted through specific training lineages and cannot be altered by the artist's personal preference.

Sand Mandala — Impermanence in Sacred Form

The Tibetan sand mandala tradition — in which teams of monks create an extraordinarily detailed mandala from colored sand over days or weeks, then ritually destroy it — is one of the most powerful living expressions of the Buddhist teaching on impermanence in any tradition. The mandala represents the palace of a specific deity in the enlightened realm — its creation is understood as the actual construction of that palace, blessing the surrounding area. Its ritual destruction — sweeping the sand into a central pile and pouring it into flowing water — is understood as the release of the blessings into the world. Nothing is held. Everything is offered.

Cham — Sacred Mask Dance

Cham is the sacred masked dance tradition of Tibetan Buddhism — performed at monastery festivals, originally linked to the subjugation of Tibet's indigenous spirits by Padmasambhava. Cham dancers wear elaborate masks representing specific deities, protectors, and animals, and perform specific choreographic sequences that are understood as the deity's own movement — the dancer temporarily becoming the vehicle for the deity's presence. Watching the Cham is understood as generating merit and purifying negative karma through sight alone.

♦ **HALIGRIC LENS: The sand mandala's creation and dissolution is the most complete sacred embodiment of the teaching on impermanence in any tradition. Not spoken about. Not philosophically analyzed. Lived — over days of painstaking creation followed by a single sweeping moment of release. The Haligric Rituals book's understanding of ceremony as a technology that enacts rather than merely represents sacred truth finds its most visually complete expression in the Tibetan sand mandala tradition.**

The Chinese People's Liberation Army entered Tibet in October 1950, and by the 1951 Seventeen Point Agreement Tibet became officially incorporated into the People's Republic of China. The initial period preserved some Tibetan cultural and religious institutions, but the failed 1959 uprising and the Dalai Lama's flight to India marked the beginning of systematic cultural destruction.

The Cultural Revolution (1966-1976) was the most devastating period for Tibetan Buddhism — approximately 6,000 monasteries were destroyed, hundreds of thousands of monks and nuns were forced to laicize, sacred objects were melted down or confiscated, and the practice of religion was prohibited. The human cost — in deaths, imprisonments, and cultural destruction — is documented by the International Commission of Jurists and numerous human rights organizations as cultural genocide.

The Tibetan diaspora — centered in Dharamsala, India, with communities in Nepal, Bhutan, Switzerland, the United States, and elsewhere — preserved the living tradition of Tibetan Buddhism outside Tibet. The paradox of the Chinese occupation of Tibet is that it scattered Tibetan Buddhist teachers throughout the Western world, where they have had an impact on Western spiritual and psychological culture that would have been impossible had they remained on the plateau. The forced diaspora became an inadvertent global transmission of the tradition's treasures.

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS: The destruction of Tibetan Buddhist civilization by the Chinese state is the most recent and most thoroughly documented example of the pattern that runs through the entire Haligric library: the systematic destruction of a sacred tradition's institutional forms by a political power that recognizes the tradition as a source of authority it cannot control. The Tibetan example is distinguished by the extraordinary response of its tradition: the Dalai Lama's sustained commitment to non-violence, the diaspora's preservation of the teachings in new cultural contexts, and the resulting global transmission of the Tibetan Buddhist heritage to a worldwide audience that might never have received it otherwise.**

Tibetan Vajrayana Buddhism and Bon together constitute one of the most significant and most directly relevant traditions in the entire Haligricity library — not as a historical curiosity but as a living transmission that has been actively engaging the Western world since the 1960s and that addresses questions Haligricity asks with extraordinary precision.

WHAT TIBETAN VAJRAYANA GOT MOST PRECISELY RIGHT

The map of consciousness across dying, death, and rebirth in the Bardo Thodol is without parallel in any tradition for its specificity, its precision, and its practical orientation toward the practitioner's actual experience. No other tradition produced a comparable document. It is the most complete sacred technology for the most universal human experience — dying — that humanity has developed.

THE TRANSFORMATION TEACHING

The Five Buddha Families teaching — that the five poisons are the five wisdoms in their unrecognized form — is the most complete expression of the Haligric understanding that nothing in human nature is an obstacle to be eliminated. Everything is wisdom waiting to be recognized. The transformation is not suppression. It is recognition. This is Haligricity's foundational understanding applied to the full range of human experience including its most difficult dimensions.

DZOGCHEN AND THE HALIGRIC RECOGNITION

Dzogchen's teaching that rigpa — primordial awareness — is already and always present, that the path is recognition rather than achievement, that you are not progressing toward something you do not yet have but recognizing what was never absent — is the most direct Buddhist statement of the Haligric recognition. The divine does not live above the human being waiting to be earned. It IS the human being's own awareness. Already. Always. Completely.

BON'S CONTRIBUTION

Bon gives Haligricity the most complete indigenous Himalayan shamanic framework — the three-world cosmology, the soul anatomy, the spirit-relationship ecology, the sacred landscape understanding, and the soul retrieval tradition that is the direct precedent for the Living Altar concept. Bon is not merely Buddhism's predecessor. It is a complete and living sacred tradition in its own right with its own Dzogchen — the recognition that the nature of mind is already perfect, arrived at through a completely

indigenous Tibetan route.

WHAT HALIGRICITY ADDS

Haligrity brings to the Tibetan traditions the recognition that the body is not a vessel to be transcended but a sacred instrument to be honored. The Tibetan tradition's most advanced practitioners demonstrate this through rainbow body — the body itself dissolving into light at the moment of recognition's completion. But the path to that dissolution moves through the body, not around it. Haligrity holds the body-honoring practices of every tradition in this library alongside the Tibetan recognition of mind's nature — sacred body and sacred mind as the two wings of the same bird.

*"O nobly born, whatever appears, however terrifying,
recognize it as the natural radiance of your own mind.
Do not be afraid. Do not be attracted. Do not follow.
Rest in the recognition.
You have always been free."*

— Bardo Thodol, synthesis of the essential instruction

❖ **HALIGRIC LENS:** On the roof of the world, between the sky and the earth, two traditions met and produced the most complete map of consciousness, death, and liberation that humanity has assembled. The Bonpo shaman's drum still beats. The Dzogchen master still rests in rigpa. The Bardo Thodol is still read at bedsides. The rainbow body still occurs in the high caves. The tradition is not past. It is present, here, now — in the recognition that is always already available to any human being willing to look at what is looking. Grand Rising.

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Parent document: Buddhism — A Complete Overview | Companion document: Japanese Shingon Buddhism